ONE

Weather

At twenty-four years old, Erica Garner-Snipes was the "spitting image" of her father. The day her aunt called to say her father had stopped breathing, she was riding the train, on her way from Queens in New York City to Staten Island. But it wasn't clear at first what had happened. *He had asthma, so was he still alive . . . in the hospital? Or worse?* The train went through a tunnel, so she lost the connection, and passengers who witnessed Erica's confusion and tears held space for her: "They prayed for me right there and then," she said. Although distraught, she was not alone.

In the weeks and months to come, tens of thousands of people who learned about the killing of Eric Garner at the hands of New York Police Department officers would hold Erica's grief as their own. She described the protests as her "support group," and observers noted how she came alive—her voice more animated and stride more energized—when leading the crowd. Erica was the eldest of four full siblings, so the fact that she picked up a bullhorn and led chants with her father's last words, "I can't breathe!" should not come as a surprise. She was used to leading a group. In the end, though, her heartbreak would prove to be too much to bear.

Eric Garner was a hands-on dad who participated in school drop-offs and pickups and helped with homework before chasing Erica and her siblings around the house. He was also a gushing grandad

who splurged on his granddaughter so she'd have a brand-new stroller and crib. He was one of those dads whose love was "thick." That's the word Toni Morrison uses to describe a love that's vast, unwavering, and swollen with affection. What happens when that thick, gushing love is suddenly taken from you, and your body cannot contain the grief?

"All I can see on that video is my Dad just trying to live for his kids, just fighting for us," Erica said. "You can hear his voice get muffled and high-pitched. It sounds like he was scared. Really scared. He wasn't fighting the police. He was fighting to breathe."

On December 30, 2017, after three years of demanding justice for her father, Erica's heart broke apart. At twenty-seven years old, it was her second heart attack; the first was just three months earlier after she had given birth to her son. This time she fell into a coma and suffered significant brain damage. One week later, at Woodhull Hospital, the same Brooklyn facility where she was born, Erica died.

In the months and years leading up to her death, Erica visited the scene of her father's killing repeatedly, leading twice-weekly protests. She supported other families whose loved ones had been killed. And she was in the process of starting an organization to support political candidates committed to police reform. This became Erica's plot. In all the ways we might imagine, she seemed to metabolize her anguish through activism. But as writer Bruce Britt observed, Erica was taking serious risks in publicly agitating against a powerful and routinely violent organization like the New York Police Department: "To have any hope of earning sympathy from her reflexively unsympathetic critics, she suppressed whatever rage she must have been feeling, opting instead to coolly advocate for due process." But what does it take for our bodies to remain cool when our spirits are burning with rage and grief?

When journalist Elizabeth Day visited Erica on the sixteenth floor of her Brooklyn high-rise, she asked Erica about her experience with racism before Officer Daniel Pantaleo choked her father to death. Erica described customers verbally harassing her, and others insisting on being served by white staff. She remembered being called a "slave" by a teenage boy—all while she worked at a

Dunkin Donuts in a predominantly non-Black area of Queens. But Erica did not sound angry: "Her voice is resigned, her shoulders slumped. At 24, her face is young but her eyes are tired and seem to belong to a much older woman. A crooked half-smile plays around her lips as she speaks. The smile sits a little oddly with the gravity of what she is saying, but then it strikes me that this is an expression of someone who copes with injustice on a daily basis." Shoulders slumped, perhaps, because of all she was carrying; a crooked smile that could not mask her sorrow. Even Erica's daughter saw through her strength, asking, "What's the matter Mommy, are you thinking about Pop-pop?" Pop-pop is what Erica called her dad.

Erica Garner-Snipes, no doubt, was weathered. Not only by the senseless loss of her father, but by a lifetime of economic precarity and everyday racism.



Arline Geronimus coined "weathering" as a public health concept in 1992 to underscore how we embody stressors and oppressors in the broader environment and how this process causes preventable illness and premature death. While the scientific establishment prefers to focus on genetic rather than sociopolitical explanations for racial health disparities, proponents of weathering and other kindred concepts are fighting to get us to consider the structural determinants of health—the institutions and processes that cause health disparities. Instead of taking the weather for granted, we must engage in our own fight against (anti-Black) climate denial. If weathering wears our bodies down, like the weather wears away even the oldest of cliff faces, how can we protect ourselves from it?

In this chapter, I focus on weathering as both a public health idea and a framework for understanding and challenging how everyone's lives and futures are affected by anti-Black racism. Here I draw from both Geronimus's public health approach and scholar Christina Sharpe's emphasis on the weather as "the totality of our environments." Sharpe makes an important point about the racism that is part of that total environment: "The weather is the total climate;

and that climate is antiblack." Taken together, weathering is one way of explaining the often devastating, yet preventable, health outcomes of Black folks because of living day in and day out in a hostile environment.

In the United Kingdom, they just call it what it is. Former prime minister Theresa May's "hostile environment policy" was rolled out in 2012 as a set of legal requirements and administrative practices designed to make living in Britain for a subset of immigrants as burdensome as possible so that they "voluntarily leave."

It led to the 2018 Windrush scandal, in which British subjects, mainly those of Caribbean descent, were made to jump through ridiculous bureaucratic hoops, were wrongly detained, lost their jobs, were deported, and were refused reentry despite being citizens of and longtime residents of the United Kingdom. But even in places without an explicit policy, hostile environments are made and remade daily through the machinations of institutions and individuals alike.

In tracing the relationship between weathering and the storm of police violence exposed in 2020, this chapter calls bullshit on the language of "preexisting conditions," which is often used to describe Black vulnerability to illness and violence. Whether we find it at political press conferences or in autopsy reports, the accusation that Black people have prior poor health places responsibility on those harmed by a sick social order rather than on harmful social conditions themselves.

Weathering includes the sudden storms that flood our lives *and* the slow droughts that create famine—a reminder that the weather comes in many forms. Acute crises like eviction, job loss, and death in the family are like hurricanes that swoop in, engulfing us with pain and heartache. But when it comes to chronic stress—watching rents creep higher and higher, job hunting with nary a callback, worrying the police will harass your child—it's like dry, hot winds scraping slowly across your face. Sure, violent storms bring us periodically to our knees, but the arid austerity of everyday life can be fatal. What is there to do when the forecast is always precarious and even the

air seems out to get us? Ration our energy, breathe shallower, *wear a mask*.

This chapter also weaves together the multiple vulnerabilities that correspond to the converging pandemics of COVID-19 and racist policing to consider how social stressors and oppressors get under our skin and into our bloodstream, burdening our organs, overloading our systems, and wearing us down over time.

We will consider how people seek to protect themselves and each other from weathering using individual practices and collective care. We will also bear witness to the weight of individual and communal protective acts and consider how all of us can be involved in sheltering one another from the rain and sun by cultivating relationships, trust, skills, accountability, and healing—starting in our own front yards. All around us there are also rainmakers showering support, planting solidarity, and creating refuge so that, ultimately, we can transform the weather.



Social epidemiologist Nancy Krieger argues that "bodies tell stories that people cannot or will not tell": bodies can confirm stories on which other people cast doubt, and bodies tell stories that people can't bear to reveal. And embodied stories, at times, can run against our collective "common sense." Socioeconomic class, for instance, is not always protective. Highly educated Black women, for example, have higher rates of preterm birth than white women with high school diplomas. Living in a rich country is not automatically good for your health. Black teen boys living in Harlem are less likely to reach age sixty-five than their counterparts in Bangladesh. In a similar vein, immigration to the U.S. does not automatically promise a "better life." Research shows many Latinx immigrants see a progressive decline in health with each subsequent generation.

Focusing only on race can sometimes hide other essential determinants of health. *Intraracial* disparities based on skin tone (i.e., colorism) are even more pronounced than many differences across

racial groups. Likewise, the "model minority myth" would lead many to expect that Asian Americans have better overall health than even whites. But when researchers disaggregate the data, they find deadly disparities between Filipino, Vietnamese, Chinese, Japanese, and Korean adults. And perhaps most surprising of all, whiteness is toxic even to its supposed beneficiaries—a matter we will return to in the pages ahead. Yet, complexity notwithstanding, we are sold simplified stories about social mobility, assimilation, racial progress, and white privilege that flatten social reality.



A few years ago, I was at the Moscone Center in San Francisco to speak at a national conference for K–12 educators. Since it was my first time at this convention, I wanted to sit in on a few sessions to soak in the conversation before it was my turn to take the stage the next day. I chose a talk in the same hall that I would be presenting in, listening in on a workshop about how teachers could better relate to their students by understanding more about generational cohorts: X, Y, Z, Millennials.

I admit that I've always been skeptical about the idea of coherent identities built around age. Born in 1978, I am technically a Gen Xer (1965–80). Generation X is described as a demographic of latchkey kids with high debt, also known as the "MTV generation." Deemed cynical and alienated slackers in our younger years, we are turning out to be happy, active adults who are heavily into Facebook, according to researchers. But more recently, those of us born at the tail of the '70s and early '80s have been dubbed a "micro generation" by the powers that be, a bridge between disaffected Gen Xers and overly optimistic Millennials, known best for our savvy uptake of technology.

Sitting at the back of that cold, airy hall, I grew irritated as I soaked up the marketing fluff presented to educators as a basis for improving pedagogy. *OK, Boomer*, I thought to myself. Naturally, I pulled out my phone to look up the speaker and, as I had guessed, she was from a firm whose entire business was to advise marketers on how to best sell products to young people. Never mind the ways

in which racism, classism, sexism, or ableism carve up young people's lives into nothing that resembles the glossy pie chart on the slides. Bubbly and with broad strokes, she was selling a story about age as a primary identity and basis of shared personality that papers over the many fault lines that shape students' experiences in and out of the classroom. As a *Washington Post* headline put it, "Your Generational Identity Is a Lie." Speaking on generational labels, sociologist Philip N. Cohen states, "Worse than irrelevant, such baseless categories drive people toward stereotyping and rash character judgment." In 2021 he and 150 demographers and social scientists wrote to the Pew Research Center urging it to ditch the labels in its surveys. This was not only because of the sweeping assumptions about a shared experience that those generational identities presume but, more pressingly, because racism, in tandem with other axes of power and difference, creates divergent climates—sheltering some while weathering others.

Two people can share a chronological age but have different biological ages due to chronic stress and persistent environmental threats. According to developmental psychologist Virginia Huynh, "Years of being followed around in a grocery store or liquor market—subtle everyday slight insults—convey to people of color and marginalized communities that they don't belong, don't fit in." And "it's often cumulative, a lifetime of experiences" that affect multiple systems in the body.

Huynh's lab at California State University, Northridge, has measured this phenomenon by collecting saliva from three hundred teenagers to assess their cortisol levels. The researchers found that those who reported experiencing discrimination had higher cortisol levels, which didn't decrease over the course of the day. In another study, the lab found that even when teenagers merely witness or overhear a racist comment, they experience spikes in cortisol, "indicating that vicarious discrimination can create a physiological response."

When it comes to measuring biological age, some researchers have been focusing on telomere length. Telomeres are DNA sequences on the ends of our chromosomes that keep them from fraying. They are like the plastic caps at the ends of shoelaces. As we age, those protective caps become shorter, and this shortening is

linked to chronic conditions like diabetes, heart disease, and strokes. In an Auburn University study on coronary artery risk development in young adults, researchers examined telomere data from nearly four hundred African Americans who were forty years old on average when the study began in 2000. Ten years later, researchers collected follow-up data, and people who reported experiences of discrimination showed a faster rate of telomere shortening, otherwise known as cellular aging.

Likewise, Geronimus and colleagues analyzed data from the Study of Women's Health across the Nation. They estimated that for women between forty-nine and fifty-five years old, Black women have a cellular age that is biologically seven and a half years "older" than white women's. Thus, the popular adage "Black don't crack" may hide the reality of weathering beneath the smooth, shea-butter-glistening surface of Black women's skin.

The nerd in me can geek out on this research all day. My inner public health advocate appreciates its utility in demonstrating the tangible harm caused by everyday racism. But the grumpy and impatient scalawag in me feels vexed that we must keep making a case for tangible harm.

Who exactly needs convincing that racism and other stressors are deadly? Whose skepticism requires that we pour more time and resources into pinpointing exactly how it erodes *our fuckin' telomeres*? Don't get me started on the headlines: "New Study Shows Racism May Shorten Black Americans' Lifespans," "Perceived Racism in Relation to Telomere Length among African American Women," "Racism Might Hurt Your Cells." I read the headlines, and then I hear the voice of writer Toni Cade Bambara asking, "What are we pretending not to know today?"

Too often, the point of studying health disparities seems to be to conduct another study that begets more funding to carry out another study, rather than to do what we can in the here and now to eliminate the sources of harm. Take the 2017 study by a team of social science and life science researchers that concluded that "father loss harms DNA."

The team conceded that when children lose a father due to death, incarceration, divorce, or separation, it affects their health and

behaviors. But *the underlying biological processes are not well understood*. And the researchers wanted to drill down and understand the precise mechanisms by which trauma gets under the skin. So they examined data produced by the Fragile Families and Child Wellbeing Study—a sample of 2,420 young people across twenty large U.S. cities who were enrolled at birth and followed throughout their lives. They set out to measure stress-induced cellular aging using telomere length and found that, indeed, adverse life events get under our skin. The team concluded, "This underscores the important role of fathers in the care and development of children." Surely we know this. The study also "supplements evidence of the strong negative effects of parental incarceration." Again, no dispute here.

But how does understanding the biological impact of father loss upend the punitive policies that create father loss in the first place? Will knowledge of their shorter telomeres engender greater public empathy for the 2.7 million children in the U.S. who have a parent serving time and the over 5 million who, at some point in their lives, have had an incarcerated parent? Or might it just solidify the popular view of "urban and disadvantaged" children as damaged, socially, culturally, and *now* biologically? We should ask ourselves whether research is serving as a stall tactic so we never collectively act on what we already know when it comes to engendering health and well-being.

I refer to this as the *datafication of injustice*—the hunt for more and more data about things we already know much about. Next thing you know, researchers will be measuring the telomeres from a blood sample of Erica Garner-Snipes.

Although technically she was a Millennial, with all that *that's* supposed to mean, Erica's body told a different story. Who exactly needs to know Erica's cellular age to verify that racism maybe, *just maybe*, shortened her life? The research community needs to reckon with how our work contributes to *structural gaslighting*—misattributing the causes of premature death to biological factors—whether we intend to conceal them or not. And rather than simply studying "race" as a safe and convenient variable in our regression analyses, we need to call out and organize against *racism* and interlocking

systems of oppression. No more euphemisms, no more feigned uncertainty, no more publications pretending we don't know why people are perishing.

I'll say it again: *the facts alone will not save us.*

What's even worse is that those in positions of authority too often use the language of science to distort the truth or flat-out lie about what has happened to people's bodies. New York Police Department chief surgeon Eli J. Kleinman concluded that Eric Garner's preexisting poor health, not the chokehold, contributed to his death.

While bullets tend to have a clear point of origin, asthma, hypertension, and other chronic illnesses have a more diffuse set of causes in the physical and social structures that we take as fixed. Garner's suffocation may have been exacerbated by his asthma, but his asthma itself was a result of environmental racism. Urban planners locate highways, trash transfer stations, and other toxic structures near Black and Latinx communities. It was *already* hard to breathe. This longer chain of connections is harder to narrate and so rarely captures the public imagination, much less a viral hashtag, except when the two converge. In Garner's death, we see how direct and indirect forms of racial violence are, and have always been, connected.

Fortunately, there is growing attention to these life-and-death connections. Led by the new Office of Resilience created in June 2020, my current home state of New Jersey has created an action plan focused on "adverse childhood experiences" (ACEs), or traumatic events that negatively affect the brain, causing lifelong, "even generational[,] emotional, physical and economic challenges." The goal of this initiative is for New Jersey to become a "trauma informed/healing centered state." Currently about 40 percent of children in the Garden State—more than 782,000—have experienced at least one ACE, and about 18 percent have experienced multiple traumas. The action plan notes that ACEs are concentrated among children of color and those living in poverty, and part of the justification for the program is that the economic burden in healthcare and social services across the nation is in the billions.

To its credit, the initiative attempts to counter the idea that ACEs cause irreparable damage, by reminding us that they do not

determine the destiny of a child, nor are they inevitable: "ACEs can be prevented, and when they do occur, concrete steps can be taken to help children, families, and communities heal from their effects. Intervening early, supporting resilience in individuals, and building resilient communities are key to mitigating the impacts of childhood trauma." The Office of Resilience aims to build statewide capacity across state and nongovernmental agencies, and communities to address the root causes of ACEs.

When I saw that the action plan mentioned "racialized violence, institutionalized racism, and white supremacy" as sites of intervention, I thought, *Word. OK, maybe this isn't another exercise in pathologizing the victims of unjust systems*. It's still too early to tell where those implementing this plan will focus. And I also wonder whether a state initiative focused on resilience can ever fully reckon with the state's central role—via police, prosecutors, and agents of the "family regulation system"—in creating the hostile weather that requires so much resilience in the first place. I don't think so, unless the most affected communities are the ones really driving the interventions. Otherwise, viral justice ends up being more like viral *tweaks* to the status quo, viral *veneer* to business as usual, and viral *rhetoric* that begins and ends with words.



While the world became accustomed to wearing physical masks during the COVID-19 pandemic, for Black folks, wearing a mask is nothing new. Long before the pandemic, Black people had to shield themselves from a hostile world as a survival strategy. Legal scholar Cheryl I. Harris begins her classic 1993 essay "Whiteness as Property" with a story from the 1930s about her white-passing grandma moving back and forth across the color line to work in a whites-only department store:

"Every day my grandmother rose from her bed in her house in a Black enclave on the south side of Chicago, sent her children off to a Black school, boarded a bus full of Black passengers, and rode to work . . . Each evening, my grandmother, tired and worn, retraced her steps home, laid aside her mask, and reentered herself. Day in

and day out, she made herself invisible, then visible again . . . She left the job some years later, finding the strain too much to bear."

Harris recalls conversations with her grandmother in which, on rare occasions, she admitted overhearing some racist comment her coworkers had made because they assumed she was white. She swallowed any response that might've been warranted, since silence was the price of opportunity. "Accepting the risk of self-annihilation was the only way to survive," as Harris puts it.

Today the color line may not be as rigid, but masking and suppression are still too often required for survival. Sixty years after Harris's grandmother risked self-annihilation, sociologist Joe Feagin found a similar pattern of racism-related vigilance in interviews with Black respondents. One older woman described having to put on her "shield" every morning: "She said that for more than six decades, as she leaves her home, she has tried to be prepared for insults and discrimination in public places, even if nothing happens that day." Although Whites Only signs don't hang in store windows at the local mall, white spaces are a social reality produced repeatedly through subtle forms of exclusion and derision.

This is why, I think, Grandma White was vigilant when it came to self-presentation. When I was going through my grunge phase as a teenager in Los Angeles—ripped jeans, oversize T-shirts, and black combat boots from the army and navy surplus supply store—our sensibilities clashed. *What was the big deal?* I thought. *Everyone does it! Why were my clothes so offensive?*

"But *you* are not 'everyone,'" she replied. Especially when it came time for me to board a bus, train, or plane, the stakes were raised. My grandma would take me to Fox Hills Mall—now known as Westfield Culver City—on a mission to purchase new outfits. And without her saying so, I knew what I was looking for: more "respectable" garb. Later that evening, she would wait in the sitting room adjacent to her bedroom where she had a special closet just for her wigs, and I'd put on a fashion show, parading in and out to a soundtrack of *oohs* and *aahs*.

Only when I became a mother did it hit me that self-presentation was my grandma's tactic for self-preservation. A few years ago, I

was folding laundry and came across my eldest son's holey jeans. I'll admit, I've hidden my children's tattered clothes in the far reaches of a closet so they couldn't find them easily. This time, however, I froze, seeing the jeans through Grandma White's eyes.

Clothes are a kind of armor, however feeble, against the snap judgments of people looking for any reason to ignore, dismiss, or harm my child. I can hardly imagine how much more clothes would've meant for my grandmother's generation. I pictured her riding the bus from Little Rock, Arkansas, to Atlanta University in the 1940s, a time when looking like a student might offer some small protection against the everyday slights and savagery of Jim Crow racism.

A starched collar, a creased skirt or trouser, white gloves—all signs that this person *belongs to someone*. A mother, an aunty, or a grandma woke up early to press that outfit. These visual indicators of care served as warnings that if she went missing, an entire community would come looking for her. My hole-ridden jeans spat in the face of that loving and terrified attempt at self-preservation.

As historian Tanisha Ford explains in her work on the politics of Black women's dress, "Possessing, embodying, and performing the brand of womanhood that institutions like Spelman and other black colleges across the South espoused became a way for black women to publicly articulate their moral aptitude in order to lift African Americans and women out of the depths of racist and sexist stereotypes." Ford points to an old photograph of four women on the steps of Atlanta University, noting how their clothes and accessory choices "lent a sense of refinement and sartorial elegance." Clothing was one more tool to protect oneself from the plague of white supremacy.



Truth be told, having my teenage sons close to me during the pandemic was a relief; there were fewer chances, it seemed, of them being harmed by those dreadful creatures feigning fear while wielding badges and bitterness. Shelter-in-place policies have their perks when a constant menace to Black folks is still on the hunt.

Anthropologist Dána-Ain Davis explains, "To be sure Black mothering can be sorrowful when we lose our children but also just the threat of losing our children can precipitate an almost constant state of sorrow. We have been losing our children for centuries: through the slave trade, the plantation system, and as a result of infant mortality. We have lost our children as a consequence of the 'war' on drugs, stop and frisk policies, and to the prison industrial complex."

And so, every day, when my sons go out for a run or to get some air, I ask them to *please* be careful. They respond with polite exasperation. And sometimes I'll catch their eye, willing them to stay safe. But I know, and they know, it's not really up to them.

Just ask Ahmaud Arbery's mother. After her twenty-five-year-old son was chased down and murdered while out jogging, she was forced to listen to the defense attorney depict Ahmaud as the *real* menace. After all, explained the defense attorney, Ahmaud had on "khaki shorts with no socks to cover his long, dirty toenails."

These are the lengths to which defenders of white violence will go to fabricate a deviant image of the slain. Imagine that attorney clawing her way through the coroner's report, casting aside all signs of victimhood, scanning head to toe, from Ahmaud's fresh haircut to his calloused runner's soles, from his bullet-grazed wrist to his shattered ribs, hunting for any whiff of deviance until finally . . . "long, dirty toenails."

For civil rights attorney and legal analyst Charles Coleman Jr., the toenail comment was the defense's attempt to portray Ahmaud as a "runaway slave," a way to "trigger some of the racial tropes and stereotypes that may be deeply embedded in the psyche of some of the jurors." Out of the nine jurors asked to determine the fate of the three white men who chased and killed Ahmaud, only one was Black in a county where Black residents form 27 percent of the population.

For some Black parents, talk of dirty toenails at a murder trial is also why our plea to *please be safe* is often accompanied by anxiety over grooming. We know that even when our grownish kids go out for a casual jog, they might end up on the run. And that their bodies, their sun-kissed, perspiring, pulsing bodies, could be conscripted to testify against them. That if they are found in the wrong place at

the wrong time, every single hair on their head will be scrutinized as defenders of white violence hunt for signs of deviance. Hence, many of us end up scrutinizing them first—lovingly, fearfully, *preventively*.

This is perhaps the most sickening part of white supremacy, that to survive, we must inhabit it, know its logics, adopt its vision, if only to evade it.

Such, too, is the inexplicable cruelty of this world. In the very act of doing something that is "good for your health," Black lives are still at risk. And not only because a violent vigilante could be on the hunt, but also because of the chronic stress of remaining vigilant. Protecting oneself from the weather can take its toll. Adrenaline and cortisol released. Blood pressure raised. Immune system suppressed.

The absurdity of healthful activity precipitating decay is enough to make even the most stubbornly hopeful among us grow weary. When it comes to racism-related vigilance, our caution may feel protective in the short term, but chronic stress slowly destroys us in the long term. When our body gets ready for "fight or flight," it becomes flooded with hormones, which is great in short bursts. But when we're *always* on edge, it can lead to hypertension and an enlarged heart, and can overstimulate our immune system to begin attacking normal cells and tissues—causing "cytokine storms," which have been linked to some of the most severe cases of COVID-19.

In his essay "The White Space," sociologist Elijah Anderson notes that white people perceive many neighborhoods, workplaces, schools, and other public places as "diverse," whereas Black people view those same places as homogeneously white. To gain provisional acceptance in such spaces, Black people have to "pass inspection" in their speech and dress. Using interviews with five hundred college-educated Black men, sociologist Rashawn Ray documented the lengths respondents go to just to exercise: running in well-lit, densely populated areas, wearing college alumni T-shirts, waving and smiling at neighbors, carrying an ID on them. Just like Grandma White—just like every Black person trying to survive the assault of everyday racism—those men are signaling, *I am not a threat*.

Anderson, who is Black, tells a story of vacationing with his family in Cape Cod, Massachusetts. The setting is idyllic: two weeks

in a beautiful cottage about a mile from town. One morning at about six o'clock, he's going for a run, enjoying the clear blue skies, and taking in the sounds of nature when a middle-aged white man in a red pickup truck stops in the middle of the road. The white man begins gesticulating and yelling for the professor to "Go home! Go home!" Two simple words, uttered with disdain, turning a healthy activity into one more leg of a dangerous race Black folks have been running for centuries.

But if such a simple exchange can suddenly transform the weather from calming and regenerative to blustery and corrosive, doesn't this mean a simple exchange could transmute the weather in the other direction if we choose?

Before my family officially moved to Princeton, Principal Jason Burr walked us around the boys' soon-to-be public middle school. I was initially caught by surprise when students chatting at their lockers in between classes—most of them white and Asian—greeted us warmly as we passed, pausing their conversations to ask Malachi and Khalil, "Hey! Where are you from?" and "When are you starting?" Before we had even unpacked our bags, these small gestures seemed to call, *Welcome home!* . . . cliquey and angsty stereotypes of tweens be damned.

Perhaps even more telling, in my eyes, was that Principal Burr himself greeted the janitorial staff mopping up a spill in the cafeteria with the same respect he did the teachers and students we passed in the halls. And over the years, those initial observations bore out—here was a school leader who did not ration respect, one who was deeply committed to making *everyone* feel welcome, and he did this less with grand gestures and more in the genuine regard he showed to each person he encountered. I'm not sure whether the students "caught it" from Principal Burr, or they inspired him, but the conviviality was contagious.



While the weather envelops all of us, as Christina Sharpe underscores, it is decisively anti-Black. We can see this in the literal masks

we wore during the pandemic, which came with an added catch for Black people. "I don't feel safe wearing a handkerchief or something else that isn't CLEARLY a protective mask covering my face to the store because I am a Black man living in this world. I want to stay alive but I also want to stay alive," tweeted Ohio resident Aaron Thomas. The goal of staying alive but also *stayin' alive* represents the longing to survive a biological threat and the multiple social threats that make it hard to rest. But how else, I wonder, could Black people use all that energy currently expended on self-preservation?

A week before Thomas's tweet, two Black men wearing hospital masks recorded themselves being followed around and kicked out of Walmart by an officer. The fact that you could endanger yourself by acting in solidarity with everyone else is surely a symptom of an ailing society. Around the same time, a Black man was dragged off a Philadelphia bus by a group of officers for allegedly not wearing a mask. The mask, it appears, was never the issue. Covered or exposed, it was always Blackness. With pandemics and police threatening us, how do we stay alive and *stay alive*?

Meanwhile, in what may seem like a parallel universe produced by white supremacy, throngs of mostly maskless white protesters staged Reopen America rallies across the country. No, COVID-19 hadn't been eradicated, but these white people exhibited an entitlement and indifference that makes us all sick, themselves included.

That's the thing about hostile weather. It can't be neatly contained. As psychiatrist and historian Jonathan Metzl describes in *Dying of Whiteness: How the Politics of Racial Resentment Is Killing America's Heartland*, many lower- and middle-class white Americans are suffering from their support of policies that cut funding for healthcare, schools, and social services. To the extent that public funding is thought to benefit racialized groups, these white folks want none of it, even if it could save their lives, too.

Racial capitalism serves up a potent cocktail of corrosive individualism, persistent anti-Blackness, and relentless grind that means many white people, too, stagger early to their graves. The violent history of settler colonialism in the U.S. required a romantic figure, the Rugged Individual, to help distract from the atrocities of

scalping, stolen children, concentration camps, broken treaties, and mass genocide. To manifest his destiny, the Rugged Individual had to declare his (alleged) independence over and over.

"All I'm for is the liberty of the individual . . . I'd like to know why the well-educated idiots keep apologizing for *lazing and complaining* people who think the world owes them a living," so lamented Hollywood film star John Wayne, an exemplar of this distorted outlook.

Now take this settler mythology and stir it up with the specter of slavery—the master who benevolently feeds, shelters, and trains his property to work. Their "childlike" dependence on him is a sign, nay *proof*, of their inferiority. The Rugged Individual finds his foil in the Helpless Horde. In our cultural imagination, Blackness is derided as the epitome of slothful dependence. For the Rugged Individual, any whiff of dependence on the state is reviled because of its association with Blackness.

"Ain't no way I would ever support Obamacare or sign up for it. I would rather die," a white former cab driver, Trevor, told Metzl during an interview. When asked the reason for his policy position, Trevor, who was suffering from an inflamed liver and having difficulty breathing—he came to the interview with an oxygen mask—responded with, "We don't need any more government in our lives. And in any case, no way I want my tax dollars paying for Mexicans and welfare queens." One starts to grasp the deep-seated contempt in America for a *Black* president who created "handouts" for *Blacks*. It appears hardworking white people can only know themselves by creating a foil: lazy, good-for-nothing n*ggers.

Never mind that this nation nursed itself on the scarred breasts of Black women and was made rich by the toiling of enslaved men, women, and children drenched in salty sweat. Never mind that the United States continues to be nourished by weathered farmhands, almost half of whom are undocumented immigrants deemed "essential." *Who* is dependent on *whom*, exactly?

It's not paradoxical so much as hypocritical and pathological. This is how the funhouse mirror of white supremacy has always worked—depicting as "needy" those whom our society needs most. But there's more. Ours is a nation that was erected on the powerful

idea that *all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights*, even as the founders held people in bondage. Rather than face up to that original sin, those drunken with patriotism today project what should be their own shame onto others.

Blackness, in brief, is a mirror reflecting America's hypocrisy, threatening the idealized story patriots want to believe about this country. Therein lies the exceptional treatment of Black people as not simply a racial "other" but an existential threat. The only way to deal with a threat is to subdue it, swiftly, with a knee to the neck . . . or slowly in the weathering wear and tear of everyday life.

The irony is that Trevor would eventually die, not only from liver damage but also from lethal policies that would deny him the care he needed. Tragically for him, the dogma of rugged individualism is mixed with contempt for interdependence in the form of a stronger social safety net, which is ultimately something that we'd all benefit from.

As it turns out, even if you earn the "wages of whiteness," your body may still be paying a price. A team of economists, Anne Case and Angus Deaton, call it the *quiet epidemic*—between 1999 and 2013, the mortality and morbidity among non-Hispanic white Americans across education levels increased due to drug and alcohol poisonings, suicide, chronic pain, and disease. The economists attributed this epidemic of death to growing despair caused by declining wages, job insecurity, and a weak social safety net over the long haul—a process they admit mirrors the plight of Black communities in the 1970s and '80s. Whiteness, we have been told, necessitates deference and comes with special privileges. But the stories told by the bodies of white people remind us that a frayed social contract eventually makes everyone sick.



White people's vulnerability to the weather and their role in creating this climate are two reasons why the language of "allyship" doesn't make any sense, as it implies dominant groups are doing something

for oppressed ones but don't need saving themselves. We are not all affected by the weather in the same way, but it encircles and impacts all our lives. And given that, the weather is anti-Black, white people's lives depend on the dismantling of anti-Blackness, as it rips apart the social fabric that they themselves are barely hanging on to by a thread.

In *White Rage: The Unspoken Truth of Our Racial Divide*, historian Carol Anderson excavates the subtle dimensions of anti-Black racism, the bureaucratization of rage, we might call it, as it infects our courts, legislatures, and the policies governing everyday life. From housing and education to voting and healthcare, whenever and wherever Black people have demanded full citizenship and access to social goods, white Americans have responded with a backlash. The trigger? Black ambition, Black resilience, and Black resolve in the face of an unceasingly hostile climate.

If the only way to justify white dominance has been to concoct a mythology of Black inferiority, then witnessing Black intelligence, ingenuity, and perseverance elicits an ongoing cultural crisis, if not pathology, for those who invented and, therefore, at some level *need* the n*gger, in James Baldwin's words. Black prosperity, in short, shines a scorching light on the lie of white supremacy.

While the idiom of white "rage" evokes the fiery heat of a cross, exemplified by the Tulsa Massacre of 1921, when white people burned a thriving Black community to the ground, the vengeful assault on Black life is often expressed in the ice-cold language of law: redlining, gerrymandering, and stop-and-frisk.

Even the federal government's Paycheck Protection Program, a cornerstone of the stimulus bill meant to offer some relief during the COVID-19 pandemic, contained provisions that disadvantaged Black businesses. By putting commercial banks in charge of administering the loans, the program gave large, majority-white businesses that had prior relationships with these lending institutions the upper hand. No Whites Only signs required, just the fine print of policy.

Cuts to public education, healthcare, and social services are today's backlash politics and form part of a long tradition of refusal. Going back to 1866, when newly free Blacks set up hundreds of

schools across the South out of an abiding belief that education could counter oppression, many poor whites refused to join the so-called n*gger programs. If there were any chance that a public good would benefit Black Americans, it seems that many whites would rather feast on imagined superiority as their stomachs growl empty. This is not simply backlash politics, but boomerang politics that comes back around to harm them too.

Take the support for pro-gun laws, another potent symbol of freedom, patriotism, and white rage. The increasing rate of white suicide, as Case and Deaton document, is linked to the easier accessibility of guns. Gun advertisers use language like "restore your manly privilege" as a direct appeal to the Rugged Individual whose fragile manliness must be constantly buttressed; guns become phallic prosthetics.

When it comes to gun ownership, it's not just masculinity that is at stake, but race and class too. In colonial America, one of the first things that the elite planter class did to divide poor, white indentured servants from enslaved Negroes was to give poor whites guns so that they could patrol runaways and put down uprisings. The ruling class, comprising the first settlers who established plantations, monopolized most of the fertile land. This monopoly earned them great fortunes, and they had no plans to share that wealth. Instead, formerly indentured white servants were paid a "psychological wage" by being armed to patrol Blackness.

The ongoing legacy of racialized policing continues to wear Black people down, one harassing encounter after another. That is no surprise. But the racial paranoia that policing fosters *and* feeds on erodes the social climate for everyone. Anti-Blackness leads to divestment from social goods like education, employment, and healthcare that would foster safety and well-being *for all.*

What's more, the same racial paranoia that drives policing also drives pro-gun laws. In April 2020, hundreds of protesters, including armed white militia, paraded around the Michigan State Capitol with semiautomatic weapons, chanting "Our House!" "Let us in!" and "Let us work!" They were protesting the governor's extension of a stay-at-home order due to COVID-19. On one level this looked

like just another display of "white privilege"—white men, even when armed to the teeth in a government building, did not elicit an aggressive police response. But is it *only* privilege at work when, in the context of over twenty-three thousand gun suicides each year, the rate among white men in the U.S. far outpaces those of other groups? From cuts to the social safety net to lenient gun laws, whiteness shows reckless disregard for even white people's safety.

Admittedly, I bring my own baggage to any discussion of gun violence. In 2016, in Hesston, Kansas, my sister-in-law was killed in her workplace. Renee "Randy" Benjamin was thirty years old and had only been working at Excel Industries in Hesston for about six months. Hesston, located approximately thirty miles north of Wichita, has a population of fewer than four thousand, and the Excel plant is one of the two largest companies in the area. Excel is renowned for manufacturing world-class outdoor power equipment like utility vehicles and riding lawn mowers, and Randy was so excited about landing her new job. She'd get home after a long shift and talk all about who worked on the line with her.

Then, on February 25, 2016, an employee opened fire on the Excel Industries plant with a semiautomatic rifle, killing Randy and two other coworkers and wounding fourteen others. We would later learn that the shooter was high on meth and alcohol and angry about being served a restraining order by an ex-girlfriend.

When my husband, Shawn, called to tell me that Randy was killed, it was the morning of my talk at the Moscone Convention Center in San Francisco—the same conference where I had been annoyed the day before about how generational identities were being sold to educators. I was still in my hotel room, racing back and forth between the bathroom and bed. I turned the phone speaker on so I could talk and get ready, when Shawn's voice broke in anguish.

Millions of Americans from all racial backgrounds are traumatized by gun violence. Yet Kansas is one of many states that allow the open and concealed carrying of handguns. It also requires no background checks for private gun sales or obtaining permits. Even among white families who have lost loved ones to gun violence (usually by suicide),

the vast majority continue to oppose gun control legislation because they need to protect themselves from "invaders."

They have a *possessive investment in whiteness*, to borrow an idea from sociologist George Lipsitz, because in their minds the invaders who most threaten their investment are usually dark and menacing. Speaking to the hostile assertiveness of those seeking to maintain their status, the phrase "possessive investment in whiteness" provides a more apt description of the dynamics going on here than, say, "white fragility" (i.e., white defensiveness). Sure, white bodies and psyches may be fragile, but white politics are aggressive and deadly.

Anthropologist Brandon Hunter-Pazzara reminds us that, in 2016, George Zimmerman auctioned the gun he used in 2012 to kill seventeen-year-old Trayvon Martin. If that wasn't depraved enough, the woman who purchased the weapon for $250,000 intended it as a present to her son.

Let's sit with this for a minute. What kind of "profound neurosis," to borrow Toni Morrison's portrayal of racism, could motivate this perverse expression of motherly love—venerating the very thing used to steal the life of someone else's child? "My feeling is that White people have a very, very serious problem," Morrison said in a PBS interview in 1993. "And they should start thinking about what they can do about it." For their *own* sakes, I would add.

The gun is a racial icon, yes, one that melds together police violence and the everyday terror of white vigilantes. Going back to the colonial era, white men have deputized themselves as keepers of the racial order, protecting the law-abiding public from *those in the streets*. But each year, almost double the number of Americans die by gun suicide that do by gun homicide, and *white males* account for seven out of ten suicides. The racial paranoia of impending invasion makes sense for a people living on stolen land. But the threat was never the man in the street or across the border. It was always the man in the mirror.

The stories of white supremacy and white bodies riddled with bullets or shot up with opioids are part of the same frayed social fabric. White gun suicide is only one way our corrupt system wreaks

havoc on those who are supposedly the beneficiaries of whiteness. What if we all, ultimately, would benefit by transforming the racist climate that, yes, rains down much harder on some but wreaks havoc on all of us in different ways?

Once and for all, we must abandon the zero-sum calculus of white supremacy. It's bad math and an even worse moral vision. True justice, as the Jamaican philosopher Sylvia Wynter waxes lyrical, is not grim retribution but shared happiness. That is not to say the way forward is all flowers and sunshine. On the contrary, it's quite the opposite. It requires treasonous activity on the part of those for whom the existing racial arithmetic was designed.

Historian Noel Ignatiev is famous for insisting that "treason to whiteness is loyalty to humanity," because, for him, white identity is synonymous with social domination. In 1997 a *New York Times* reporter asked Ignatiev, "You're white. Do you hate your own hide?" He responded, "No, but I want to abolish the privileges of the white skin. The white race is like a private club based on one huge assumption: that all those who look white are, whatever their complaints or reservations, fundamentally loyal to the race. We want to dissolve the club, to explode it."

What does that look like in practice? For Ignatiev, it involved defying race-based expectations and standing up for justice. And it entailed long-term commitment in the everyday ways that white Americans can choose to break the code. There are examples of white people doing this—like abolitionist John Brown, who, in 1859, led a raid on a federal armory at Harpers Ferry, Virginia. Or like Anthony Huber and Joseph Rosenbaum, who, in 2020, were killed defending fellow Black Lives Matter protesters from gunman Kyle Rittenhouse in Kenosha, Wisconsin. But the first rule for abolishing the White Club is to admit that there is a White Club—one that is devastating to those excluded *and* that poisons those who enjoy privileged membership. In a heated public conversation with writer Chinua Achebe, James Baldwin had this to say:

> We are in trouble. But there are two ways to be in trouble. One of them is to know you're in trouble. If you know you're in trouble you may be able to figure out the road.

> This country is in trouble. Everybody is in trouble—not only the people who apparently know they are in trouble, not only the people who know they are not white. The white people in this country . . . *think* they are white: because "white is a state of mind." I'm quoting my friend Malcolm X . . . white is a moral choice.

A choice between white and *what*, Baldwin does not say exactly, perhaps because it's an open question, one that fostering viral justice can begin to answer.

Beyond the most obvious bad actors, we also must reckon with the reality that many of the policies and structures that govern our lives work directly against the social good, pushing a corrosive individualism cloaked in the language of "freedom." After all, the people typically in charge of creating antisocial policies can afford private healthcare, private education, private property—even private environments (from locating hazardous waste near low-income areas to blocking access to hundreds of beaches "for residents only"). The very people who don't believe in a commons are the ones designing an antisocial system for the rest of us to inhabit.

We're living inside a deadly game, one that was set up to ensure there would be winners and losers. Within such a world, racism will always be necessary to justify why some people seem to be winning, some losing, and others losing *their lives*. But in this context, we shouldn't simply strive for "more winners." We need to stop playing the game. We need to build entirely new worlds and ways of being with one another that don't involve resting on the necks of losers.

Viral justice requires that we challenge the corrosive individualism that infects every area of our lives, and work against the revolting distortion of "freedom" that prioritizes a sick individualism over mutual obligations. As poet Adrienne Rich said, "In the vocabulary kidnapped from liberatory politics, no word has been so pimped as 'freedom.'" The deadly strain of freedom, a freedom from mutual obligation, breaks society, erodes mutuality, grinds down our ability to care for one another, and eats away at any notion of a collective good.

Until we reckon with the fact that racism is productive, we'll continue to be caught off guard by its persistence and reissuance. Productive not in the sense of being "good" but in the literal sense of being able to produce things of value to some, even as it wreaks havoc on others. These productions include everything from segregated neighborhoods in which white assets appreciate and Black assets depreciate to the carceral system that preys on Black communities while providing employment, lucrative contracts, and cheap labor, especially for rural America. Racism also produces an international division of labor and resource extraction whereby the U.S. and Europe export garbage recycling to rural workers in China and India, import fast fashion made by child labor in Sri Lanka and conflict minerals for our cell phones from the Congo, outsource obscene internet images that digital content moderators in the Philippines and Kenya must wade through and delete, while formerly colonized nations continue to provide cheap workers to rich countries like the U.S.

We are taught to think of racism as a surprise storm surge, an aberration, a glitch, an isolated incident, a bad apple, in the backwoods, as outdated, rather than as a centuries-long climate, business as usual, the entire operating system, an attached incident, the entire orchard, in the halls of power, innovative, even viral. In sociology we often say, "Race is socially constructed," as in it is not natural or biologically determined. But we often fail to state the corollary, that racism *constructs*—sometimes literally, in the case of segregated neighborhoods and prisons, but also, more subtly, in the production of racialized threats.

This production can be seen, for example, in the portrayal of eighteen-year-old Michael Brown by the officer who killed him in 2014. To his friends, Brown was a "gentle giant" with a wicked sense of humor. To Officer Darren Wilson, he "had the most aggressive face. That's the only way I can describe it, it looks like a demon, that's how angry he looked." Racist vision produced a demon where someone's friend once stood. Anti-Black weather enveloped residents of Ferguson well before that friend lay dead in the scorching-hot sun.



Before her untimely death, Erica Garner-Snipes was working mightily to make justice viral. So, too, are many family members who have lost loved ones to police violence, including Erica's grandmother, Gwen Carr. She is part of the Mothers of the Movement, a group of Black women whose children have been killed by police or gun violence. They've joined forces to educate the public about police brutality and support others dealing with the same trauma.

In 2015 Carr retired from her job as a train operator for New York City's Metropolitan Transportation Authority, and she now devotes her time to civil rights. After the murder of George Floyd in 2020, she was one of the first people to call and console the Floyd family. "Don't forget. You cannot let this go," she insisted.

But Carr admits that, at first, she was reluctant to get involved. In her memoir, dedicated to the memory of Erica, Carr describes her reluctance: "I don't think I am particularly brave or strong . . . I suppose I could just sit back and live off my pension and have a decent life and move to Florida and soak up the sunshine . . . but that was not how I wanted to spend my life."

Now in her early seventies, she's an active participant in the Movement for Black Lives—speaking at protests, helping to pass New York State's antichokehold bill, meeting with lawmakers in DC to advocate for the George Floyd Justice in Policing Act, working against the return of stop-and-frisk in New York City. Indeed, Carr is a testament to the fact this isn't only young people's work. We *each* have a choice to make, whether or not we've had our children swept away by the deadly storm of state violence or whether we've experienced racism's toxic weather in other forms. Viral justice requires that we direct energy not only outward but also inward at the layers of grief, rage, even shame that threaten to break open our hearts.

Recall the three types of work that organizer and founder of the mutual aid resource website Big Door Brigade, Dean Spade, outlines: dismantling harmful systems, providing for the immediate needs of people targeted by those systems, and creating alternatives to the harmful status quo. These are all essential elements for transmuting hostile environments. Organizations like Project NIA, founded by Mariame Kaba, offer hands-on tools and curricula for individuals

and communities to use in transforming a culture designed to stifle Black life. "And if you think that this work is like programming a microwave," Kaba remarked, "where an input leads to immediate output, that's capitalism speaking."

Instead, growing the world we want is like the slow tending of a garden, transforming the plants by fostering relationships, trust, skills, community accountability, and healing. It requires cultivating new habits *internally*, seeding restorative ways of being together *interpersonally*, uprooting practices of inequality *institutionally*, and planting alternative possibilities *structurally*. If we only concentrate on our internal work while ignoring the fires burning all around us, we'll eventually be consumed. But if we only concentrate on putting out the blaze, we'll eventually burn out.

When it comes to collective healing as a foundation for social transformation, my friends Claudia Pena and Beth Ribet have taught me so much. Building on their work as community organizers and legal scholars, they started a Los Angeles–based organization called Repair that addresses a wide range of issues, from human trafficking and white nationalism to disability law and policy. Beth is a survivor of child sex trafficking, and her experience deeply informs the organization's approach to trauma and healing by moving beyond diagnosis to prescribing practical tools. These include the Healing Circles Project, which aims to build peer-led mental health supports; Tea Parties, which are community workshops on food justice and plant medicine; and Transformation, a series of lectures, conversations, and storytelling sessions about healing and social action. The one I attended focused on trust. One of my friends, Naimeh, noted how the feeling of intimacy and the courage of the speakers made her want to be more vulnerable and open. "It's kinda contagious," she said.

The point is, we can't wait for top-down change to engender alternatives. Rather, grassroots efforts are an essential part of world-building. Not to mention, "grassroots" can literally mean working in the grass! Ron Finley, aka the "gangsta gardener," is a longtime resident of South Central Los Angeles, "home to the drive-thru and drive-by," as he puts it. But Finley is changing the earth one plot at

a time. In 2010 he grew frustrated with how residential segregation had made it hard to purchase affordable fresh vegetables in his neighborhood. So he decided to plant food in his front yard. Well, not exactly his front yard—in the stretch of grass called the "parkway" between the sidewalk and the street:

> Funny thing is, the drive-thrus are killing more people than the drive-bys. People are dying from curable diseases in South Central Los Angeles . . . I got tired of seeing this happening . . . I see dialysis centers pop up like Starbucks. And I figured, this has to stop. So I figured that the problem is the solution. Food is the problem and food is the solution . . . So what I did, I planted a food forest in front of my house.

Pumpkins, peppers, sunflowers, kale, and corn. At first, the city cited him and threatened to issue a warrant for his arrest, but the idea caught on. Eventually, Finley and supporters got the city to change the law that prevented people from growing edible landscapes on parkways. Now he and his team at Green Grounds have planted over twenty urban gardens around LA. They also created a teaching garden to spread knowledge about organic farming with the aim of also creating jobs for local residents. "Growing your own food is like printing your own money," Finley likes to say.

For Finley, it was never simply about the food, though. He gets emotional talking about food-insecure neighbors who were shocked when they realized they could take whatever they wanted from his yard for free. His philosophy is to give a person a vegetable but also teach them how to farm, so they have skin in the game: "The air is better . . . you're changing the ecosystem when you put in a garden. We are part of the ecosystem, so that garden is changing us. And then that *beauty* factor! You get to walk out your door and experience nature every day. That's going to change you. I don't care how jaded you are."

Beauty is not frivolity, a luxury, nor should it be an afterthought. Even under the harshest conditions, we hunger not only for food but also for beauty and meaning . . . which is why art, aesthetics, and imagination are vital to world-building.



In the end, there is weather and there is *weather*. As long as there are skies above, there'll be storms that rain down on us below. Such is life. And sometimes the rain is even refreshing, putting out fires and washing away the stuff that weighs us down. But whether we drown in the water or find refuge together is another matter entirely.

We all know our parents will eventually die and, although we brace ourselves for that reality, we are rarely prepared when it happens. But there's no reason we should watch our fathers be suffocated to death by agents of the state, as Erica Garner-Snipes did, or have our mothers suffer two heart attacks (literally heart *aches*) by the age of twenty-seven, as Erica's children did. Many of us are forced to brace for some version of swift or slow death, a death we know is not inevitable but rather the result of a hostile racial climate and all the small, everyday ways that it leaves people deserted.

Recall how Michael Brown was not only shot down by Officer Darren Wilson in Ferguson, Missouri. Black folks being shot and killed by police is an all-too-common occurrence, but that his body lay outside in the middle of the street for hours in the sweltering summer heat brings to mind the title of an article in the *Atlantic* by journalist Adam Serwer: "The Cruelty Is the Point." Residents in surrounding apartments peered out their windows in disbelief at Brown's lifeless body—a horrific symbol of how so many communities are left out to dry. This shameful postmortem showed weathering—how even *in death* Black people are left exposed. *This* is what galvanized the movement for Black lives.

What, then, is the opposite of social abandonment? Not grand announcements, posturing, and virtue signaling, but caring complicity even when there's no audience to bear witness. In the Minneapolis neighborhood surrounding the site of George Floyd's murder, you'll see the usual signs—"Black lives matter" and "Abolish the police"—in people's yards and windows. But there's one in particular, leaning up against a tree, that speaks to an even deeper longing: "Take care of each other."

Here is a call for complicity that is not about what we need to change *out there* but rather about how we need to treat one another in our more intimate interactions that'll never make the headlines. Conspiring to care for one another is how we change the weather. It's what Minneapolis-based organizations Black Visions Collective and Reclaim the Block have been engaged in since 2017 and 2018: hosting popular education sessions, building trust with community members, hosting monthly Black Joy Sundays that encourage neighbors to connect and network, and crucially, prioritizing the physical well-being of organizers by hosting health justice workshops focused on the somatic impacts of racism.

In the aftermath of Floyd's murder, these local organizations swiftly mobilized local residents—calling city council members every night, sending them research, and even littering politicians' yards with handmade gravestones bearing Floyd's image—until, eventually, nine of the thirteen council members walked on stage at a rally led by Black Visions in Powderhorn Park, the neighborhood where Floyd was murdered. It was just thirteen days after Floyd's murder that the council members publicly pledged to dismantle the police. Making history, it turns out, is the result of years of planting and uprooting, tending and pruning—one community gathering, one direct action, one Black Joy Sunday at a time. This is how we all transform the weather. But the struggle continues.

As the first step in dismantling the police, Minneapolis education officials announced plans to sever ties between law enforcement and the public schools, a feat that my friend Marika Pfefferkorn and other local activists had been working on for several years. But then the school district set out to hire "public safety support specialists," and according to leaked résumés, of the twenty-four finalists, a majority were police officers, private security guards, and corrections officers. The job description, after all, stated a preference for applicants with "degrees and experience in criminal justice." You see, *right there*, in the fine print, a deadly status quo was seeded: a closed-door meeting to decide qualifications, the mindless typing up of a job description, the routine posting on a human resources page. This is where the school-to-prison pipeline begins.

So let's not be fooled. Politicians can stand up in front of thousands to proclaim their commitment to grand policy changes, as we witnessed in Powderhorn Park. Governments can give in to public pressure and rework city budgets so resources are invested where we think they should be. But as Marika, the executive director of the Midwest Center for School Transformation, points out, "If you don't actually change the culture of the system, you just replace who's doing it." She's right. It isn't possible to change a social structure without changing its culture, and we can't change culture without changing ourselves.



In December 2014, the night that New York City grand jury decided not to charge Officer Pantaleo in the chokehold death of her father, Erica Garner-Snipes sat in the back seat of a taxicab, stunned and reeling with anguish. Vexed by the traffic, the driver cursed under his breath at the crowds making their way across the Brooklyn Bridge. It didn't click at first, until Erica looked out the window and saw waves of people, bundled up with hats and gloves, of all ages and backgrounds, carrying cardboard coffins, staging die-ins in the middle of the street, holding signs—"I can't breathe"—and chanting her father's name. Suddenly, her pain was *our* pain, her anger *our* anger. Leaning out the window, she cried, "Thank you! *I'm* Eric Garner's daughter." A large throng surrounded the cab, calling back to Erica, "We love you, we're doing this for you guys!" That simple exchange parted the clouds: "It felt like, *wow.*"

It turns out, transforming the weather doesn't require magical powers. It just requires that we begin to plot—emboldening one another, strengthening our relationships, watering the alternatives we want to grow, and shouting love in all we do. Whether your plot is organizing protests, making art, or sabotaging the White Club, whether it's interrupting racist school practices, advocating for fair work conditions, or parenting the next generation of tillers, love is always there, just beneath the surface, nourishing all our efforts.